

Word family: **fragile / fragility / fragilely**

Base word: fragile

Related forms: fragility, fragilely

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / related noun and adverb forms (相關名詞及副詞)

Your sentence:

> “I think sea turtles are interesting because they are both **fragile** and resilient at the same time.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **fragile** means **easily harmed, damaged, or threatened**, especially in the sense that sea turtles may be vulnerable despite also being able to survive difficult conditions.

繁體中文： **容易受到傷害、破壞或威脅的；脆弱的**

中文翻譯：

> “They are both **fragile** and resilient at the same time.”

「牠們同時既**脆弱**，又很有韌性。」

Here:

fragile = 容易受外在環境、危險或傷害影響的

1. **fragile = easily broken or damaged physically (物理) — 易碎的；脆弱的**

This is the central literal meaning.

Meaning: Easily broken, cracked, damaged, or destroyed.

Practice 1

> “Be careful with the glass—it is very **fragile**.”

「小心那個玻璃，它非常**易碎**。」

Practice 2

> “The old paper is extremely **fragile**.”

「那張舊紙非常**脆弱 / 容易破損**。」

****fragile = 物理結構不耐受力、碰撞或壓力，容易破裂或受損的****

Common:

- * fragile glass
- * fragile object
- * fragile material
- * fragile surface

2. ****fragile = physically weak / vulnerable living thing (生物 / 健康) — 脆弱的；體弱的****

A person, animal, ecosystem, etc. can be ****fragile**** when easily harmed or unable to withstand stress well.

This is the meaning family used in your passage.

Practice 3 — Original

> “Sea turtles are both ****fragile**** and resilient.”

「海龜同時既****脆弱****又有韌性。」

Practice 4

> “The young animal was still very ****fragile****.”

「那隻幼小動物仍然非常****脆弱****。」

Practice 5

> “The ecosystem is extremely ****fragile****.”

「這個生態系統非常****脆弱****。」

****fragile = 對傷害、壓力、環境變化或危險抵抗力較低，容易受到破壞的****

This is a major figurative/biological extension of the physical-breakage sense.

3. ****fragile = emotionally vulnerable (情緒) — 脆弱的；容易受傷的****

A person's emotional state can be described as **fragile** when they are easily upset, hurt, or destabilized.

Practice 6

> "He was emotionally **fragile** after the loss."

「失去那件事後，他的情緒非常**脆弱**。」

Practice 7

> "She seemed **fragile** and easily upset."

「她看起來很**脆弱**，很容易受影響。」

fragile = 情緒上容易受傷、受刺激或失去穩定的

This is a common figurative use.

4. **fragile** = delicate / unstable situation or system (情況 / 制度) — 不穩定的；脆弱的

A relationship, agreement, economy, peace, system, etc. can be **fragile** if it can easily collapse or be damaged.

Practice 8

> "The peace agreement remains **fragile**."

「和平協議仍然非常**脆弱 / 不穩定**。」

Practice 9

> "Their relationship was already **fragile**."

「他們的關係本來已經很**脆弱**。」

fragile = 某個制度、關係、局勢或狀態缺乏穩定性，容易崩潰或惡化

This is distinct enough for learners because the idea shifts from physical damage to structural instability.

5. **fragile** = delicate in appearance or build (外形) — 纖細的；柔弱的

****Fragile**** can describe someone or something that looks delicate, slight, or easily harmed.

Practice 10

> “She had a small, ****fragile**** frame.”

「她身形細小，看起來很****纖弱****。」

Practice 11

> “The flower looked beautiful but ****fragile****.”

「那朵花看起來美麗但很****嬌嫩脆弱****。」

****fragile = 外形纖細、嬌嫩或給人容易受損的感覺****

For strict counting, I would merge this with Meaning 2.

Related form: ****fragility****

****Fragility**** means the quality or state of being fragile.

Practice 12

> “The accident revealed the ****fragility**** of the system.”

「那宗意外暴露了這個系統的****脆弱性****。」

Practice 13

> “The ****fragility**** of the ecosystem is a major concern.”

「這個生態系統的****脆弱性****是一個重要問題。」

****fragility = 容易受損、崩潰或受影響的性質 / 狀態****

This works physically, emotionally, socially, or structurally.

Related form: ****fragilely****

****Fragilely**** means in a fragile or delicate manner, but it is ****rare in everyday English****.

A more natural expression is often:

- * delicately
- * weakly
- * in a fragile way

So I would include **fragilely** only as a low-priority family form.

Important distinction: **fragile vs weak**

weak

means lacking strength or power.

fragile

means easily damaged, broken, or destabilized.

Something can be:

> strong but fragile

For example, a material may be hard but shatter easily.

So:

weak = 力量不足

fragile = 容易受損 / 崩潰

Important distinction: **fragile vs delicate**

delicate

can mean:

- * fine
- * sensitive
- * requiring careful handling
- * aesthetically refined

****fragile****

more strongly emphasizes:

> easily broken, harmed, or destabilized

> delicate flower

> fragile glass

There is overlap, but ****fragile**** usually carries more risk of damage.

Important distinction: ****fragile vs vulnerable****

****vulnerable****

means exposed to harm, attack, or risk.

****fragile****

means inherently easy to damage or destabilize.

A person or species can be:

> vulnerable because of external danger

and also:

> fragile because of low resilience.

The two often overlap but are not identical.

Important distinction: ****fragile vs sensitive****

****sensitive****

means easily affected by stimuli, criticism, change, etc.

****fragile****

suggests a stronger risk of being damaged or destabilized.

> sensitive skin

> fragile health

Different emphasis.

Important distinction: **fragile vs resilient**

This is the key contrast in your sentence.

fragile

= easily harmed or damaged

resilient

= able to recover, endure, or continue despite difficulty

These are not perfect opposites in every context.

Something can be both:

> **fragile and resilient**

That is exactly the idea in your passage: sea turtles may be vulnerable to harm yet still capable of surviving long journeys and harsh conditions.

Useful label: **fragile ecosystem — 脆弱生態系統**

Practice 14

> “Coral reefs are often described as **fragile ecosystems**.”

「珊瑚礁常被形容為**脆弱的生態系統**。」

This belongs to Meaning 2/4 depending on whether the focus is biological vulnerability or system instability.

Useful label: **fragile state / fragile system — 脆弱狀態 / 脆弱系統**

Practice 15

> “The network remained in a **fragile state**.”

「網絡仍處於**不穩定 / 脆弱狀態**。」

This belongs to the unstable-system sense.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **fragile**

* **fragility**

Low-priority form:

* **fragilely**

The family is genuinely small. Most learning value comes from the semantic spread across:

* physical breakability

* biological vulnerability

* emotional vulnerability

* unstable relationships/systems

The Golden Manual says small families should remain small, while figurative and domain extensions should still be checked carefully.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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fragile — physical	物理結構容易破裂、折斷或受損的；易碎 / 脆弱
fragile — living thing/ecosystem	對傷害、壓力或環境變化抵抗力較低、容易受破壞的
fragile — emotional	情緒上容易受傷、受刺激或失去穩定的
fragile — relationship/system/situation	缺乏穩定性、容易崩潰、惡化或受到破壞的
fragile — delicate appearance	外形纖細、嬌嫩、給人容易受損感覺的；與 vulnerability 義相關
fragility	容易受損、崩潰或受影響的性質 / 脆弱性

For your original sentence

> “I think sea turtles are interesting because they are both **fragile** and resilient at the same

time.”

The exact meaning is:

****fragile = 容易受到環境、危險或外在因素傷害的脆弱狀態****

So:

> ****fragile and resilient****

= ****既脆弱，又有很強的適應和恢復能力****

For your database, I would count ****4 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****fragile****:

1. ****physically easy to break or damage****
2. ****biologically/physically vulnerable****
3. ****emotionally vulnerable****
4. ****unstable and easily damaged/collapsed — relationship, system, situation****

I would merge delicate appearance into #2 and keep ****fragility**** as the main family extension rather than inflate the core count.